locking horns like two bulls, and though the Indians would be wiped out, the Chinese casualties would mount. The second option was to ignore the brigade and capture the heights behind them, thereby cutting off any chance of the troops escaping; the Indians could then be systematically encircled and wiped out. However, here again, it would be risky, as Chinese troops would not only have to fight Indian troops dug in above them, they would also have a large body of Indian troops behind them. The third option would be to attack both flanks—Khenzemane and Tser Jang Tso—while directing the main strike towards the left flank of the middle section (Bridge 4 to Bridge 3 held by 2 Rajput). While pinning the Indians down from the front, they would also assault from the rear after having infiltrated through the positions during the hours of darkness preceding H-hour. This would isolate the Indians into many small sections and these could then be wiped out, thereby ensuring maximum casualties. The plan was sent to Chairman Mao in Peking who gave the go-ahead. The Chinese could now ‘gallop up, eat up India’s one brigade, that is 7 Brigade, that was lying in front’.

Accordingly, 155 Regiment and one battalion of 157 Regiment were to take on the four Rajput positions and the Assam Rifles post at Dhola, while the main body of 157 Regiment was to simultaneously assault 1/9 GR positions and also cut off the track from Bridge 1 to Hathung-la, thereby trapping 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers. While the 2nd Battalion of 31 Regiment was to engage the Rajputs from across the Nam Ka Chu, their role was to pin them down long enough for the attacks to develop from the rear. Finally, 154 Regiment was to launch a battalion-sized attack on the Khenzemane post and the grenadier position at the Drokung Samba Bridge while the remainder of the regiment was to rapidly move down the eastern bank of the Nyamjang Chu Valley and threaten 4 Division HQ at Zimithang.

## DALVI’S DILEMMA

On the Indian side, from the humble tradesmen (cooks, dhobis and others) to NCOs, JCOs, officers, battalion commanders, brigade staff up to HQ 4 Division, every man knew the ridiculous deployment along the Nam Ka Chu was a certain death trap. After 10 October, when the realization that the Chinese also had guns had hit Kaul, there had been the unspoken hope that the general’s departure for Delhi would finally result in an order that would allow 7 Brigade to extricate itself from the Nam Ka Chu Valley and take up